Flame Tests: Identifying Metal Ions by Color

U2 / S2.5

NAME _____ DATE _____ PERIOD _____

GROUP MEMBERS _____

GOALS

- Run a flame test safely: one clean stick per solution, tip in the flame for a few seconds.
- Record the flame color of nine known compounds, and compare each one with its expected color.
- Identify three unknowns by matching their flame colors to the known compounds.
- Explain each color with ground and excited states: electrons absorb energy, drop back, and give off light.
- Record each color in your lab notebook the moment you see it, not from memory afterward.

PURPOSE

You will heat twelve solutions and watch the color each one gives the flame. Nine are known compounds and three are unknowns. By the end of the period you will name the three unknowns using nothing but the colors you recorded.

BACKGROUND

Heat excites electrons. In the flame, electrons in the metal ions absorb energy and jump from their ground state to higher energy levels. That excited state does not last. Each electron drops back down and gives off the energy as a photon of light.

The size of the drop sets the color. A photon's energy equals the gap between the two levels. A bigger drop gives more energy and a shorter wavelength, toward violet. A smaller drop gives a longer wavelength, toward red. Each metal has its own set of energy levels, so each gives off its own mix of colors.

The color comes from the metal ion. Sodium nitrate and sodium chloride both give a yellow flame, because the sodium ion is doing the work. That is why the table below lists ions, not whole compounds. Two cautions: the wooden stick itself burns yellow-orange once it catches, so watch the **first two or three seconds**; and a color is a clue, not proof, because two ions can give nearly the same color.

ION IN THE COMPOUND	SYMBOL	TYPICAL FLAME COLOR
Lithium	Li^+	Crimson red
Sodium	Na^+	Yellow
Potassium	K^+	Lilac
Calcium	Ca^{2+}	Orange-red
Strontium	Sr^{2+}	Red
Barium	Ba^{2+}	Pale green
Copper(II)	Cu^{2+}	Blue-green

The same colors as your S2.5 notes. Cobalt and iron are not on this table: for those two, predict what you think you will see, then record what you actually see.

SAFETY

- Splash goggles go on before any burner is lit and stay on until every station is cleaned up, including while other groups are still testing.
- Long hair is tied back and loose sleeves are pushed up before you reach toward a flame. The flame on a burner can be nearly invisible in a bright room. Assume it is lit.
- A wet stick can catch fire in the flame. Hold only the dry end, keep the tip in the flame for just a few seconds, and if the tip keeps burning, drop it in the sink. Never set a burning or used stick on the bench.
- The nitrates on the list (sodium, potassium, calcium, barium, copper and iron nitrate) are oxidizers: they make wood and paper burn faster. Keep paper, notebooks and the box of clean sticks away from the flame.
- Several solutions are harmful if swallowed or if they touch your skin or eyes, especially the barium, copper and cobalt compounds. Never taste, smell or touch a solution. If one gets on your skin, rinse it with running water and tell me. In your eyes: go straight to the eyewash, hold your eyelids open for at least 15 minutes, and send a group member for me immediately.
- Do not pick up or move a sample cup. If one tips over, step back and tell me. Do not wipe it up yourself.
- Report every spill, including water. Water on the floor is how people fall.

PRE-LAB — DUE AT THE START OF THE PERIOD

Answer all of these in your lab notebook, numbered 1 through 8, before you walk in. Do not write on this handout. You will not be allowed to light a burner without the pre-lab finished.

1. Use the words **ground state** and **excited state** to describe what happens to an electron in the flame, from the moment it absorbs energy to the moment light comes out.
2. Sodium nitrate and sodium chloride give the same flame color. What does that tell you about which part of a compound makes the color?
3. Look at the reference table. Name the two ions whose colors are hardest to tell apart, and explain why that is a problem when you are identifying an unknown.
4. Read Part B, step 2. How much of the stick goes into the solution, and where do you hold it in the flame?
5. Read Part B, step 3. Why do you record the color from the first two or three seconds and not after that?
6. Read Part B, steps 4 and 5. What happens to a stick after one test, and why is a stick never dipped into a second solution?
7. The tip of your stick catches fire and keeps burning. Say exactly what you do. Then write where the fire blanket and the eyewash are in this room.
8. Set up the data table in your notebook, in ink, exactly as shown below: one row for each of the twelve samples. Fill in the **Expected color** column from the reference table before you walk in. For cobalt, iron and the unknowns, leave it blank.

TABLE 1 · FLAME TEST RESULTS (12 ROWS: STATIONS 1–6, TWO SAMPLES EACH)

Compound (name and formula)	Expected color	Actual color
Lithium chloride, LiCl		
Sodium nitrate, $NaNO_3$		
… one row for each sample, in station order …		
Unknown C		

MATERIALS

At each of the six stations: Bunsen burner and striker · two labeled sample cups of solution · a cup of clean wooden stir sticks (one per test, per student) · nothing else on the bench but your lab notebook, closed and away from the flame.

STATION	SAMPLE 1	SAMPLE 2
1	Lithium chloride, $LiCl$	Sodium nitrate, $NaNO_3$
2	Potassium nitrate, KNO_3	Calcium nitrate, $Ca(NO_3)_2$
3	Strontium chloride, $SrCl_2$	Barium nitrate, $Ba(NO_3)_2$
4	Copper(II) nitrate, $Cu(NO_3)_2$	Cobalt(II) chloride, $CoCl_2$
5	Iron(II) nitrate, $Fe(NO_3)_2$	Unknown A
6	Unknown B	Unknown C

PROCEDURE

Part A — Set up at your first station

1. Go to the station I assign. Goggles on, hair tied back, sleeves up.
2. Light the burner the way you learned in the Intro Skills Lab, and adjust it to a steady blue flame with a visible inner cone.
3. Read both labels. Find those two rows in your table before you test anything.

Part B — Test each solution

ABOUT 5 MINUTES PER STATION

1. Take one clean stick for each student in your group. Hold it by the dry end.
2. Dip only the tip, about 1 cm, into the first solution for a few seconds. Then hold the wet tip at the edge of the flame, just above the blue inner cone.
3. Watch the color the instant the tip enters the flame. Record it in the **Actual color** column before you do anything else.
   - After two or three seconds the wood itself starts to burn yellow-orange. That color is the stick, not the solution. Do not record it.
   - Each person tests and records their own sample. Compare colors with your group, but write what you saw.
4. Drop the used stick in the sink. Never put a used stick back into any solution: it carries the first metal into the second sample and every group after you sees the wrong color.
5. Repeat steps 1–4 with the second solution, using new sticks.
6. Leave the burner lit. When I call "rotate," move to the next station number (station 6 moves to station 1). Do not move early.

Part C — The unknowns

1. Unknowns A, B and C are tested at stations 5 and 6 exactly like the others. Each one is a compound you have already tested.
2. Record the actual color in the unknown's row. Leave the identification for the post-lab.

DATA TABLES

You built Table 1 in your pre-lab. Have it open and ready before the first stick goes into a solution, and fill in each color **as you see it**, not at the end of the period.

Describe the color you see, not the color you expect. "Red" is not enough when there are two reds on the table: say crimson, bright red or orange-red, and whether it was strong or faint. If you write something wrong, draw one line through it and write the correction beside it.

DISPOSAL AND CLEANUP — LAST FIVE MINUTES

1. Every used stick goes in the sink, never the trash can, where a smoldering stick could start a fire. I collect them from the sink after class.
2. The sample cups stay at their stations, exactly where they were. Do not pour any solution out, down the drain or anywhere else. I collect and store them.
3. Turn the gas off at the valve, then leave the burner where it is until it is cool to touch. Put the box of clean sticks back on the cart.
4. **Wash all glassware with the Alconox solution in the blue spray bottle.** Spray inside, scrub with a brush, and rinse thoroughly — soap left in a beaker changes the next measurement made in it.
5. Rinse with distilled water and invert everything on the rack to dry.
6. Wipe your bench, push in your stool, and wash your hands. **Goggles come off last**, once the whole room is finished — not once you are.

POST-LAB ANALYSIS

Answer these in your lab notebook, numbered 1 through 3.

1. Identify unknowns A, B and C. For each one, name the known compound it matches and the color evidence from your table. PART C
2. Pick one unknown that could have matched two different known compounds. Name both, explain why the flame color alone could not settle it, and say what you would use to decide. REFERENCE TABLE
3. Find one compound whose actual color did not match its expected color, or cobalt or iron, which had no expected color. Give a specific reason from the procedure that could explain what you saw. "Human error" is not a reason. PART B